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READINGS
FOR
ORDINARY TIME

VOLUME IV

WEEKS 13 - 23

PRO MANUSCRIPTO
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WEEK 13

SUNDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Sam. 5:16 – 6: 5a, 10 – 12, 19 – 7:1*

The Ark of God is sent back into Israel.

A reading from the first book of Samuel.

When the Philistines captured the ark of God, they carried it from Ebene'zer to Ashdod; then the Philistines took the ark of God and brought it into the house of Dagon and set it up beside Dagon. And when the people of Ashdod rose early the next day, behold, Dagon had fallen face downward on the ground before the ark of the LORD. So they took Dagon and put him back in his place. But when they rose early on the next morning, behold, Dagon had fallen face downward on the ground before the ark of the LORD, and the head of Dagon and both his hands were lying cut off upon the threshold; only the trunk of Dagon was left to him. This is why the priests of Dagon and all who enter the house of Dagon do not tread on the threshold of Dagon in Ashdod to this day. The hand of the LORD was heavy upon the people of Ashdod, and he terrified and afflicted them with tumours, both Ashdod and its territory.

And when the men of Ashdod saw how things were, they said, "The ark of the God of Israel must not remain with us; for his hand is heavy upon us and upon Dagon our god." So they sent and gathered together all the lords of the Philistines, and said, "What shall we do with the ark of the God of Israel?" They answered, "Let the ark of the God of Israel be brought around to Gath." So they brought the ark of the God of Israel there. But after they had brought it around, the hand of the LORD was against the city, causing a very great panic, and he afflicted the men of the city, both young and old, so that tumours broke out upon them. So they sent the ark of God to Ekron. But when the ark of God came to Ekron, the people of Ekron cried out, "They have brought around to us the ark of the God of Israel to slay us and our people."

They sent therefore and gathered together all the lords of the Philistines, and said, "Send away the ark of the God of Israel, and let it return to its own place, that it may not slay us and our people." For there

was a deathly panic throughout the whole city. The hand of God was very heavy there; the men

who did not die were stricken with tumours, and the cry of the city went up to heaven.

The ark of the LORD was in the country of the Philistines seven months. And the Philistines called for the priests and the diviners and said, "What shall we do with the ark of the LORD? Tell us with what we shall send it to its place." They said, "If you send away the ark of the God of Israel, do not send it empty, but by all means return him a guilt offering. Then you will be healed, and it will be known to you why his hand does not turn away from you."

And they said, "What is the guilt offering that we shall return to him?" They answered, "Five golden tumours and five golden mice, according to the number of the lords of the Philistines; for the same plague was upon all of you and upon your lords. So you must make images of your tumours and images of your mice that ravage the land, and give glory to the God of Israel; perhaps he will lighten his hand from off you and your gods and your land.

The men did so, and took two milch cows and yoked them to the cart, and shut up their calves at home. And they put the ark of the LORD on the cart, and the box with the golden mice and the images of their tumours. And the cows went straight in the direction of Beth-she'mesh along one highway, lowing as they went; they turned neither to the right nor to the left, and the lords of the Philistines went after them as far as the border of Beth-she'mesh.

And he slew some of the men of Beth-she'mesh, because they looked into the ark of the LORD; he slew seventy men of them, and the people mourned because the LORD had made a great slaughter among the people. Then the men of Beth-she'mesh said, "Who is able to stand before the LORD, this holy God? And to whom shall he go up away from us?" So they sent messengers to the inhabitants of Kir'iath-je'arim, saying, "The Philistines have returned the ark of the LORD. Come down and take it up to you."

And the men of Kir'iath-je'arim came and took up the ark of the LORD, and brought it to the house of Abin'adab on the hill; and they consecrated his son, Elea'zar, to have charge of the ark of the LORD.

Responsorial. Ps. 5: 8; 75: 8

R: I, because of your great mercy, will enter into your house. * I will prostrate myself with fear in your holy temple.

V: You are terrible, who can resist when your anger breaks out?

R: I will prostrate myself with fear in your holy temple.

Second Reading. Nm. 32 – 33

A good thing is prayer together with fast and almsgiving.

A reading from the treatise “On the Our Father” of St. Cyprian, bishop and martyr.

Moreover, those who pray should not come to God with fruitless or naked prayers. Petition is ineffectual when it is a barren entreaty that beseeches God. For as every tree that does not bring forth fruit is cut down and cast into the fire; assuredly also, words that do not bear fruit cannot deserve anything of God, because they are fruitful in no result. And thus Holy Scripture instructs us, saying, “Prayer is good with fasting and almsgiving.” For He who will give us in the day of judgment a reward for our labours and alms, is even in this life a merciful hearer of one who comes to Him in prayer associated with good works. Thus, for instance, Cornelius the centurion, when he prayed, had a claim to be heard. For he was in the habit of doing many alms-deeds towards the people, and of ever praying to God. To this man, when he prayed about the ninth hour, appeared an angel bearing testimony to his labours, and saying, “Cornelius, your prayers and your alms have gone up in remembrance before God.”

Those prayers quickly ascend to God that the merits of our labours urge upon God. Thus also Raphael the angel was a witness to the constant prayer and the constant good works of Tobias, saying, “It is honorable to reveal and confess the works of God. For when you and Sarah were in prayer, I did bring the remembrance of your prayers before the holiness of God.

He promises that He will be at hand, and says that He will hear and protect those who, loosening the knots of unrighteousness from their heart, and giving alms among the members of God’s household according to His commands, even in hearing what God commands to be done, do themselves

also deserve to be heard by God. The blessed Apostle Paul, when aided in grave affliction by his brethren, said that good works that are performed are sacrifices to God. "I am full," said he, "having received from Epaphroditus the things which were sent from you, they are an odour of a sweet smell, a sacrifice acceptable, well pleasing to God." For when one has pity on the poor, he lends to God; and he who gives to the least gives to God -he sacrifices spiritually to God an odour of a sweet smell.

Responsorial. *Sir. 3: 29- 30 (Vulg. 3: 33-34); Pr. 16: 6*

R: Water puts out a lit fire, almsgiving expiates sins: * And he who does good will find a support when he falls.

V: Faults are expiated with goodness and faithfulness.

R: And he who does good will find a support when he falls.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Neh. 4:1-17*

Construction of the wall of Jerusalem.

A reading from the book of Nehemiah.

Now when Sanbal'lat heard that we were building the wall, he was angry and greatly enraged, and he ridiculed the Jews. And he said in the presence of his brethren and of the army of Sama'ria, "What are these feeble Jews doing? Will they restore things? Will they sacrifice? Will they finish up in a day? Will they revive the stones out of the heaps of rubbish, and burned ones at that?" Tobi'ah the Ammonite was by him, and he said, "Yes, what they are building -- if a fox goes up on it he will break down their stone wall!

Hear, O our God, for we are despised; turn back their taunt upon their own heads, and give them up to be plundered in a land where they are captives. Do not cover their guilt, and let not their sin be blotted out from thy sight; for they have provoked you to anger before the builders.

So we built the wall; and the entire wall was joined together to half its height. For the people had a mind to work. But when Sanbal'lat and Tobi'ah and the Arabs and the Ammonites and the Ash'dodites heard that the

repairing of the walls of Jerusalem was going forward and that the breaches were beginning to be closed, they were very angry; and they all plotted together to come and fight against Jerusalem and to cause confusion in it. And we prayed to our God, and set a guard as a protection against them day and night.

But Judah said, "The strength of the burden-bearers is failing, and there is much rubbish; we are not able to work on the wall." And our enemies said, "They will not know or see till we come into the midst of them and kill them and stop the work." When the Jews who lived by them came they said to us ten times, "From all the places where they live they will come up against us." So in the lowest parts of the space behind the wall, in open places, I stationed the people according to their families, with their swords, their spears, and their bows.

And I looked, and arose, and said to the nobles and to the officials and to the rest of the people, "Do not be afraid of them. Remember the Lord, who is great and terrible, and fight for your brethren, your sons, your daughters, your wives, and your homes." When our enemies heard that it was known to us and that God had frustrated their plan, we all returned to the wall, each to his work. From that day on, half of my servants worked on construction, and half held the spears, shields, bows, and coats of mail; and the leaders stood behind all the house of Judah, who were building on the wall. Those who carried burdens were laden in such a way that each with one hand laboured on the work and with the other held his weapon; all the builders, working, each carried his sword strapped on to his belt. The trumpeter was besides me. Then I said to the nobles, to the magistrates and to the rest of the people: "The work is great and extensive and we are spread out on the wall and distant from one another. Therefore when you hear the sound of the trumpet, gather together near us; our God will fight for us". Thus we continued the work, while half of my people held the spears in their hands, from dawn to the rising of the stars. In that occasion I said to the people: "everyone with his helper will pass the night inside Jerusalem, in order to keep guard with us during the night and we will take up the work again in the daytime". I then, my brothers, my servants and the men on guard who follow me, will never remove our clothes; everyone held his weapon near at hand.

Responsorial. *Is. 25: 4; Ps. 45: 2*

R: Lord, you are the support of the wretched, support of the poor in his anguish: * shelter from the tempest, shadow against the heat.

V: God is for us a refuge and strength, help that is always near in anguish:

R: shelter from the tempest, shadow against the heat.

Second Reading. *Disc. 3 on the Resurrection.*

Be awake, so that the morning light may rise on you.

A reading from the “Discourses” of the blessed Guerrico, abbot.

Keep watch, brothers, praying incessantly. Stay awake and act with prudence. Stay awake above all because the dawn of the day without sunset has arisen, after the eternal light, on his return from the underworld, he has shown himself to us more serene and favourable, and the dawn has brought us a new sun. Truly “it is already time to wake up from your sleep” now that “the night has far gone, the day is close at hand” (Rm. 13: 11-12). Be awake because the light of morning, Christ, rises above you; he whose “origins are from ancient times, from the most remote days” (Mic. 5: 1) he is ready to renew often the mystery of his morning resurrection for those who keep awake for him. Then with a heart full of joy you will be able to sing: “God, the Lord is our light. This is the day made by the Lord: let us rejoice and exult in it” (Ps. 117: 27, 24); when, that is, he has let his light that he holds hidden in his hands shine for you, saying to the one who is his friend that she is his good and that it is possible for him to rise up to her.

“Till when, O lazy man, will you remain sleeping? When will you shake away your sleep? A little sleep, a little dozing, a little crossing of the arms to rest” (Pr. 6: 9-10); and during your sleep, without you realizing it, the Christ came out of the tomb, and while his glory passed you did not deserve to see him even from behind. Then you will repent too late, and crying you will have to say with the wicked: “We have therefore deviated from the way of truth, the light of justice has not shone for us, nor has the sun risen for us” (Wis. 5: 6). “For you instead, lover of my name”, he says, “the sun of justice with its beneficial rays will rise” (Ml. 3: 20) and the eyes of he who walks in justice will see the king in his splendour. (cfr. Is. 33: 15-17).

Certainly here it deals with the beatitude of eternal life, but in a certain measure we are granted his consolation in the present life also, as the evidence of the resurrection of Christ demonstrates.

Let the spirit of each one of us rise and be revived therefore, both to pray with attention, and to occupy itself in assiduous work, thus proving, with renewed and active energy, that it has newly participated in the resurrection of Christ. In truth, the first indication of the return of man to life is his valid and diligent action; but his perfect resurrection, in as much as it is possible for this mortal body, comes about when he opens his eyes to the contemplation, that the intellect cannot receive if first the heart has not been dilated with frequent sighs and ardent desires, in order to render itself capable of such a great majesty.

The resurrection progresses in the heart gradually as it dilates with the practise of prayer. The resurrection is perfect when the intellect is illuminated by the contemplation. Make efforts therefore to rise always more, brothers, climbing these steps of virtue and progressing in a life that is always holier, in order to reach as much as is possible, as the apostle says, up to the resurrection of Christ from the dead, he who lives and reigns forever and ever. Amen.

Responsorial. *Lk. 12: 35-36; Mt. 24: 42*

R: Be dressed ready for service and keep your lamps burning; * be like men waiting for their master to return from a wedding banquet.

V: Be awake therefore, because you do not know in which day your Lord will come.

R: Be like men waiting for their master to return from a wedding banquet.

YEAR A

Gospel *Mt. 10: 37-42*

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

Whoever loves father or mother more than me is not worthy of me; and whoever loves son or daughter more than me is not worthy of me; and whoever does not take up the cross and follow me is not worthy of me.

Those who find their life will lose it, and those who lose their life for my sake will find it. "Whoever welcomes you welcomes me, and whoever welcomes me welcomes the one who sent me.

Whoever welcomes a prophet in the name of a prophet will receive a prophet's reward; and whoever welcomes a righteous person in the name of a righteous person will receive the reward of the righteous; and whoever gives even a cup of cold water to one of these little ones in the name of a disciple--truly I tell you, none of these will lose their reward."

Third Reading. *Disc. 96: 1-4*

If you want to follow Christ, turn to the cross:

Tolerate it, carry it, do not be cast down.

A reading from the "Discourses" of Saint Augustine, bishop

The command of the Lord seems to be hard and heavy: if someone wants to follow me, let him deny himself. But the commands of the one who helps to fulfil all that he prescribes cannot be hard or heavy. And what he says is true: "My yoke is sweet and my burden light" (Mt. 11: 30). Charity in fact makes that which is heavy for you in the commandments light. We know what love is capable of. Often it is reprehensible and unrestrained; how many hard things men have borne, how many unworthy and intolerable things have they tolerated in order to reach that which they loved! And since these are many persons as is their love, they need to worry not so much as how they live, but how to choose that which is worthy of being loved; why therefore do you marvel if he who loves Christ and wants to follow him, loving him denies himself? If in fact the man is lost loving himself, undoubtedly denying himself he finds himself (cfr. Mt. 10: 39).

Who would not want to follow Christ there where total happiness, supreme peace, eternal security is to be found? It is a good thing to follow him up to there, but it is necessary to consider the way. The Lord Jesus did not say these words when he had already risen from the dead. He had not yet suffered, but he was getting ready to face the cross, the dishonour, the insults, the scourging, the thorns, the wounds, the disgrace, and death. The way is very hard: you are lazy and do not want to follow him.

Follow him: the road which man has constructed is bristly, but Christ has levelled it going laboriously over it backwards.

Who would not want to run towards glory? Greatness is pleasing to all; but humility is a stair. Why do you lift your foot more than you can? Do you want to fall instead of going up? Start from the first step and already you are high up. Those two disciples, who said to the Lord: "Let one of us

sit at your right hand and the other at your left in your glory” (Mk. 10: 37) did not want to stretch out towards this step of humility. They were searching for elevated places and did not see the step. But the Lord indicated it to them: what did he answer in fact? “Can you drink of the chalice that I drink?” (Mk. 10: 38). You who aspire to the peak of exaltation, can you drink the chalice of humility? Therefore he does not say only “Deny yourself and follow me” but he adds: “Take up your cross and follow me” (Mt. 16: 24).

What does: Take up your cross signify? Bear all that is irritating: thus you will follow me. When you will begin to follow me practising my examples and my commandments, you will find many opponents, many who will impede you and dissuade you, and these even among the same followers of Christ. Those who prohibited the blind from crying out were walking with Christ. Therefore if you want to follow, consider as a cross the threats that delude as well as any other impediment: tolerate, carry, do not succumb. The martyrs have been stimulated by these words of the Lord. If they were persecuted, were they not to despise everything for love of Christ?

Responsorial. *2 Tm. 3: 11-12; cfr. Jdt. 8: 27*

R: What persecutions have I suffered: Yet the Lord has liberated me from all of them. * In fact, everyone who wants to live a godly life in Christ Jesus will be persecuted.

V: As he passed our fathers through the crucible in order to test them, so also now with the aim of correcting them the Lord punishes those who are faithful to him.

R: In fact everyone who wants to live a godly life in Christ Jesus will be persecuted.

YEAR B

Gospel. *Mk. 5: 21-43*

A reading from the Gospel of St. Mark.

When Jesus had crossed again in the boat to the other side, a great crowd gathered around him; and he was by the sea. Then one of the leaders of the synagogue named Jairus came and, when he saw him, fell at his feet

and begged him repeatedly, "My little daughter is at the point of death. Come and lay your hands on her, so that she may be made well, and live." So he went with him. And a large crowd followed him and pressed in on him.

Now there was a woman who had been suffering from haemorrhages for twelve years. She had endured much under many physicians, and had spent all that she had; and she was no better, but rather grew worse. She had heard about Jesus, and came up behind him in the crowd and touched his cloak, for she said, "If I but touch his clothes, I will be made well." Immediately her haemorrhage stopped; and she felt in her body that she was healed of her disease.

Immediately aware that power had gone forth from him, Jesus turned about in the crowd and said, "Who touched my clothes?" And his disciples said to him, "You see the crowd pressing in on you; how can you say, 'Who touched me?'" He looked all around to see who had done it. But the woman, knowing what had happened to her, came in fear and trembling, fell down before him, and told him the whole truth. He said to her, "Daughter, your faith has made you well; go in peace, and be healed of your disease."

While he was still speaking, some people came from the leader's house to say, "Your daughter is dead. Why trouble the teacher any further?" But overhearing what they said, Jesus said to the leader of the synagogue, "Do not fear, only believe." He allowed no one to follow him except Peter, James, and John, the brother of James.

When they came to the house of the leader of the synagogue, he saw a commotion, people weeping and wailing loudly. When he had entered, he said to them, "Why do you make a commotion and weep? The child is not dead but sleeping." And they laughed at him. Then he put them all outside, and took the child's father and mother and those who were with him, and went in where the child was. He took her by the hand and said to her, "Talitha cum," which means, "Little girl, get up!" And immediately the girl got up and began to walk about (she was twelve years of age). At this they were overcome with amazement. He strictly ordered them that no one should know this, and told them to give her something to eat.

Third Reading. *Disc. 34*

With God death is truly to sleep.

A reading from the "Discourses" of St. Peter Chrysologus, bishop

All the evangelical readings, dearest brothers, offer us the great goods of the present and the future life. But the reading of today summarizes all that which concerns hope and excludes every reason for desperation. Now however let us speak of the head of the synagogue who, while he leads Christ to his daughter, offers a woman the way to reach Christ. The reading of today begins like this: “Then one of the leaders came to him; he threw himself at his feet and begged him with insistence: My daughter is at the point of death, come and impose your hands on her so that she may be healed and live” (Mk. 5: 22, 23). Conscious of the future, Christ did not ignore the fact that he would encounter that woman: from her the head of the Jews would learn that God did not need to move from one place to another, nor to be led by a road, or pressed for a physical presence; but it is necessary to believe that God is present in every place, entirely, everywhere and always, and that he can do everything only by willing it, without effort: to give strength, not take it away; deliver from death with a command, not with the hand; give life with an order, not with medicine.

“My daughter is on the point of death, come” (Mk. 5: 23). As if to say: the heat of life still remains, still a semblance of breath is to be seen, the spirit has not left her yet, the lord of the house has a daughter, the kingdom of the dead has not yet seen the child: hurry, therefore, in order to hold back the soul which is about to come out of her body. Fool, do you believe that Christ could not resurrect the child simply by taking her by the hand. Therefore Christ when he reaches the house and sees that the child was as if for them already lost, in order to move the unbelieving hearts to faith, says that she is not dead but sleeping: so that they could believe that it was easier to raise from the dead than from sleep. He said: “The child is not dead, but asleep” (Mk. 5: 39).

For God death is truly a sleep, because he raises to life more quickly than one who is sleeping can be awakened by another; and God infuses his vivifying heat into the cold members of a dead person more rapidly than a man can make the energy return into people who are immersed in sleep. Listen to the Apostle: “In a flash, in the twinkling of an eye, the dead will be raised” (1 Cor. 15: 52).

The blessed apostle, not having found words to express the instantaneousness of the resurrection, explains it with examples. With what

briefness could he have been able to narrate the immediacy of the resurrection, when the divine power anticipated even this?

And in what way could he speak of the time, when the eternal goods are given to us without limit of time? As the time has in itself the temporary, so also eternity does not have time.

Responsorial. *1 Cor. 15: 55-56, 57; Is. 65: 16*

R: O death, where is your victory? O death, where is your sting? The sting of death is sin. * Thanks be to God who gives us victory through our Lord Jesus Christ. Alleluia.

V: The ancient tribulations will be forgotten, they will be hidden to my eyes.

R: Thanks be to God who gives us victory through our Lord Jesus Christ. Alleluia.

YEAR C

Gospel. *Lk. 9: 51-62*

A reading from the Gospel of St. Luke.

When the days drew near for him to be taken up, he set his face to go to Jerusalem. And he sent messengers ahead of him. On their way they entered a village of the Samaritans to make ready for him; but they did not receive him, because his face was set toward Jerusalem. When his disciples James and John saw it, they said, "Lord, do you want us to command fire to come down from heaven and consume them?" But he turned and rebuked them. Then they went on to another village.

As they were going along the road, someone said to him, "I will follow you wherever you go." And Jesus said to him, "Foxes have holes, and birds of the air have nests; but the Son of Man has nowhere to lay his head." To another he said, "Follow me." But he said, "Lord, first let me go and bury my father." But Jesus said to him, "Let the dead bury their own dead; but as for you, go and proclaim the kingdom of God."

Another said, "I will follow you, Lord; but let me first say farewell to those at my home." Jesus said to him, "No one who puts a hand to the plough and looks back is fit for the kingdom of God."

Third Reading. *Disc. For the 1st Sun. of Nov.*

Let us follow him with the commitment of a holy life.

A reading from the “Discourses” of St. Bernard, abbot.

Many times and in many ways God not only spoke through the prophets, (cfr. Heb. 1:1) but was also seen by them. David knew him made inferior to the angels; Jeremiah also saw him conversing with men on the earth; Isaiah attested that he had seen him now on a very high throne, now not only among the angels or among men, but as a leper, and that is not only in the flesh, but as if clothed in a flesh of sin.

You too, if you desire to see Jesus the Most High, must first try to see him humble first. Look first at the serpent lifted up in the desert, if you wish to see the King who sits on the throne. That vision lowers you in order that this may exalt you because you will be humiliated. That mortifies and heals your pride, so that this may fill and satisfy your desire.

You will be similar to him when you will see him as he is; you will be similar to him now also, contemplating that which he has become for you.

If you do not shun a certain similarity with him in humility, certainly the similarity with him in glory will also await you. He will not tolerate the exclusion of the one who has been his companion in tribulations from the communion of his glory. In a word, he does not disdain the one who is a consort of his passion and he welcomes him in his kingdom, as the thief who repented on the cross was with him in paradise on the same day.

This is why the apostle says: “You are those who have persevered with me in my trials; and I will prepare a kingdom for you” (Lk. 22: 28-29). Since therefore, if we suffer with him, with him we will also reign, now let our mediation, brothers, be Christ and Christ crucified. Let us put him as a seal on our hearts, as a seal on our arm. Let us embrace him with the embrace of reciprocal love, let us follow him with the commitment of a holy life. This our way, which is the same that was run by him, the salvation of God, is truly not without beauty and splendour, but on the contrary it is so luminous that it fills the whole universe with his majesty.

Responsorial. *1 Pet. 2: 21; Mt. 8: 17*

R: Christ also suffered for us * leaving us an example, so that we could follow in his steps.

V: He has taken our diseases and carried our illnesses,
R: leaving us an example, so that we could follow in his steps.

MONDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Sam. 7: 15 – 8: 22*

Israel demands a king.

A reading from the first book of Samuel.

Samuel judged Israel all the days of his life. And he went on a circuit year by year to Bethel, Gilgal, and Mizpah; and he judged Israel in all these places. Then he would come back to Ramah, for his home was there, and there also he administered justice to Israel. And he built there an altar to the LORD. When Samuel became old, he made his sons judges over Israel. The name of his first-born son was Jo'el, and the name of his second, Abi'jah; they were judges in Beer-sheba. Yet his sons did not walk in his ways, but turned aside after gain; they took bribes and perverted justice. Then all the elders of Israel gathered together and came to Samuel at Ramah, and said to him, "Behold, you are old and your sons do not walk in your ways; now appoint for us a king to govern us like all the nations."

But the thing displeased Samuel when they said, "Give us a king to govern us." And Samuel prayed to the LORD. And the LORD said to Samuel, "Hearken to the voice of the people in all that they say to you; for they have not rejected you, but they have rejected me from being king over them. According to all the deeds that they have done to me, from the day I brought them up out of Egypt even to this day, forsaking me and serving other gods, so they are also doing to you. Now then, hearken to their voice; only, you shall solemnly warn them, and show them the ways of the king who shall reign over them."

So Samuel told all the words of the LORD to the people who were asking a king from him. He said, "These will be the ways of the king who will reign over you: he will take your sons and appoint them to his chariots and to be his horsemen, and to run before his chariots; and he will appoint for himself commanders of thousands and commanders of fifties, and some to plough his ground and to reap his harvest, and to make his implements of war and the equipment of his chariots. He will take your daughters to be perfumers and cooks and bakers. He will take the best of your fields and vineyards and olive orchards and give them to his servants. He will take the

tenth of your grain and of your vineyards and give it to his officers and to his servants. He will take your menservants and maidservants, and the best of your cattle and your asses, and put them to his work. He will take the tenth of your flocks, and you shall be his slaves. And in that day you will cry out because of your king, whom you have chosen for yourselves; but the LORD will not answer you in that day."

But the people refused to listen to the voice of Samuel; and they said, "No! but we will have a king over us, that we also may be like all the nations, and that our king may govern us and go out before us and fight our battles." And when Samuel had heard all the words of the people, he repeated them in the ears of the LORD. And the LORD said to Samuel, "Hearken to their voice, and make them a king." Samuel then said to the men of Israel, "Go every man to his city."

Responsorial. *1 Sam. 10: 19; Is. 33: 22*

R: Today you have repudiated your God, * who alone will save you from all your evils and from all your anguish.

V: The Lord is our judge and our legislator, the Lord is our king.

R: Who will save you from all your evils and from all your anguish.

Second Reading. *Nm. 34 – 35*

We have to persevere all day in prayer.

A reading from the treatise “On the Our Father” of St. Cyprian, bishop and martyr.

And in discharging the duties of prayer, we find that the three children with Daniel, being strong in faith and victorious in captivity, observed the third, sixth, and ninth hour, as it were, for a sacrament of the Trinity, which in the last times had to be manifested. The worshippers of God in time past having spiritually decided on such spaces of hours made use of these determined and lawful times for prayer. And subsequently the reality was manifested, of which these things were of old signs, that in the past that righteous men prayed in this manner. For upon the disciples at the third hour the Holy Spirit descended, who fulfilled the grace of the Lord's promise. Moreover, at the sixth hour, Peter, going up unto the house-top, was instructed as well by the sign as by the word of God admonishing him

to receive all to the grace of salvation, whereas he was previously doubtful of receiving the Gentiles to baptism. And from the sixth hour to the ninth, the Lord, being crucified, washed away our sins by His blood; and that He might redeem and quicken us, He then accomplished His victory by His passion.

But for us, beloved brethren, besides the hours of prayer observed of old, both the times and the sacraments have now increased in number. For we must also pray in the morning, that the Lord's resurrection may be celebrated by morning prayer. Also at the sun's setting and at the decline of day, of necessity we must pray again. For since Christ is the true sun and the true day, as the worldly sun and worldly day depart, when we pray and ask that light may return to us again, we pray for the advent of Christ, which shall give us the grace of everlasting light. Moreover, the Holy Spirit in the Psalms manifests that Christ is called the day. But if in the Holy Scriptures the true sun and the true day is Christ, there is no hour excepted for Christians wherein God ought not frequently and always to be worshipped; so that we who are in Christ — that is, in the true Sun and the true Day — should persevere throughout the entire day in petitions, and should pray; and when, by the law of the world, the revolving night, recurring in its alternate changes, succeeds, there can be no harm arising from the darkness of night to those who pray, because the children of light have the day even in the night. For when is he without light who has light in his heart? Or when has he not the sun and the day, whose Sun and Day is Christ?

Responsorial. *Jm. 5: 16; 1 Th. 5: 17, 18*

R: Pray for one another that you may be healed, * The prayer of a righteous man is powerful and effective.

V: Pray unceasingly; this in fact is the will of God in Christ Jesus.

R: The prayer of a righteous man is powerful and effective.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Neh. 5: 1 –19*

Nehemiah frees the people from the oppression of the rich.

A reading from the book of Nehemiah.

Now there arose a great outcry of the people and of their wives against their Jewish brethren. For there were those who said, "With our sons and our daughters, we are many; let us get grain, that we may eat and keep alive." There were also those who said, "We are mortgaging our fields, our vineyards, and our houses to get grain because of the famine."

And there were those who said, "We have borrowed money for the king's tax upon our fields and our vineyards. Now our flesh is as the flesh of our brethren, our children are as their children; yet we are forcing our sons and our daughters to be slaves, and some of our daughters have already been enslaved; but it is not in our power to help it, for other men have our fields and our vineyards."

I was very angry when I heard their outcry and these words. I took counsel with myself, and I brought charges against the nobles and the officials. I said to them, "You are exacting interest, each from his brother." And I held a great assembly against them, and said to them, "We, as far as we are able, have bought back our Jewish brethren who have been sold to the nations; but you even sell your brethren that they may be sold to us!"

They were silent, and could not find a word to say. So I said, "The thing that you are doing is not good. Ought you not to walk in the fear of our God to prevent the taunts of the nations our enemies? Moreover I and my brethren and my servants are lending them money and grain. Let us leave off this interest. Return to them this very day their fields, their vineyards, their olive orchards, and their houses, and the hundredth of money, grain, wine, and oil which you have been exacting of them." Then they said, "We will restore these and require nothing from them. We will do as you say." And I called the priests, and took an oath of them to do as they had promised. I also shook out my lap and said, "So may God shake out

every man from his house and from his labour who does not perform this promise. So may he be shaken out and emptied."

And all the assembly said "Amen" and praised the LORD. And the people did as they had promised. Moreover from the time that I was appointed to be their governor in the land of Judah, from the twentieth year to the thirty-second year of Ar-ta-xerx'es the king, twelve years, neither my brethren nor I ate the food allowance of the governor. The former governors who were before me laid heavy burdens upon the people, and took from them food and wine, besides forty shekels of silver. Even their servants lorded it over the people. But I did not do so, because of the fear of God.

I also held to the work on this wall, and acquired no land; and all my servants were gathered there for the work. Moreover there were at my table a hundred and fifty men, Jews and officials, besides those who came to us from the nations that were about us.

Now that which was prepared for one day was one ox and six choice sheep; fowls likewise were prepared for me, and every ten days skins of wine in abundance; yet with all this I did not demand the food allowance of the governor, because the servitude was heavy upon this people.

Remember for my good, O my God, all that I have done for this people.

Responsorial. *Ne. 5: 7, 8, 9*

R: Nehemiah said to the nobles and to the magistrates: We have ransomed our brother Jews who had been sold to foreigners; * and you would sell your brothers so that they can be sold to us?

V: That which you are doing is not good; should you not walk in the fear of our God?

R: and you would sell your brothers so that they can be sold to us?

Second Reading. *Hom 33*

We have to pray waiting for God with our spirit engrossed.

A reading from an ancient homily of the Vth century.

We must pray not through a physical habit nor through the habit of mumbling, or of keeping quiet or of kneeling down; but rather waiting for God with a spirit engrossed, when he will make himself present and will visit the soul through all of its external faculties and the ways of the organs

of sense; and thus, either keeping quiet or praying in a loud voice, let the mind be fixed in God.

Like the body, when it does something, is completely occupied in that which it is doing, and all of its members offer it their mutual help: so also the whole soul must be intent towards prayer and towards the love of God, without occupying itself in vain things or letting itself be distracted by worries, having placed all its hope in the expectation of Christ.

Only in this way will he who teaches the way of prayer and suggests a pure and spiritual oration, worthy of God, illuminate us, and the adoration made “in spirit and truth” (Jn. 4: 24).

As in fact the merchant does not only devise a way for making money, but worries about increasing it and accumulating it through every means, passing from one industrious idea to another, and undertaking journeys and abandoning that which is useless he occupies himself with that which renders the most: so also we must adorn our soul with various industry, in order to gain for ourselves the true and greatest riches, God, who teaches us to pray in truth. In this way God rests in the good desire of the soul and makes it the seat of his glory taking possession and dwelling in her.

And like a house in which the master is present and everything is beautiful, well adorned and clean, so also the soul that is inhabited by its God is full of every beauty and splendour; it is in fact the dwelling and seat of the Lord with all his spiritual treasures.

When he has seen then that the soul searches constantly for him with all its strength, that it waits for him day and night, and in every worry it cries unceasingly to him according to his teaching (cfr. Lk. 18: 7), then, as he has promised, he himself will be its defence and, having purified it of all malice, he will constitute it his bride irreprehensible and without stain (cfr. Col. 1:22).

For the rest, if you retain these things to be true, as they are, worry about yourself: let your soul possess the light that can direct it, the true food and drink is the Lord. If you are still far away, search for him day and night in order to possess him.

When you look at the sun, search for the true sun: in fact you are blind. When you see the light, look at your soul, if you have attained the good and true light. All that is seen, is the shadow of the spiritual truths. Beyond the man who perceives there is another interior man, with other eyes that Satan has blinded; with ears that he has made deaf.

Exactly in order to restore the health to this interior man Jesus came: to him be the glory and the kingdom with the Father and the Holy Spirit, forever and ever. Amen.

Responsorial. *Is. 56: 6, 7*

R: The foreigners, who have adhered to the Lord in order to serve him and to love the name of the Lord, I will fill with joy in my house of prayer. *
Because my temple will be called a house of prayer for all the nations.

V: Their holocausts and their sacrifices will be pleasing on my altar.

R: Because my temple will be called a house of prayer for all the nations.

Gospel. *Mt. 8: 18 – 22*

Follow me.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

Now when Jesus saw great crowds around him, he gave orders to go over to the other side. And a scribe came up and said to him, "Teacher, I will follow you wherever you go." And Jesus said to him, "Foxes have holes, and birds of the air have nests; but the Son of man has nowhere to lay his head." Another of the disciples said to him, "Lord, let me first go and bury my father." But Jesus said to him, "Follow me, and leave the dead to bury their own dead."

TUESDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Sam. 9: 1 – 6, 14 – 10:1*

Saul is elected king, he receives the anointing.

A reading from the first book of Samuel.

There was a man of Benjamin whose name was Kish, the son of Abi'el, son of Zeror, son of Beco'rath, son of Aphi'ah, a Benjaminite, a man of wealth; and he had a son whose name was Saul, a handsome young man. There was not a man among the people of Israel more handsome than he; from his shoulders upward he was taller than any of the people.

Now the asses of Kish, Saul's father, were lost. So Kish said to Saul his son, "Take one of the servants with you, and arise, go and look for the asses." And they passed through the hill country of E'phraim and passed through the land of Shal'ishah, but they did not find them. And they passed through the land of Sha'alim, but they were not there. Then they passed through the land of Benjamin, but did not find them. When they came to the land of Zuph, Saul said to his servant who was with him, "Come, let us go back, lest my father cease to care about the asses and become anxious about us."

But he said to him, "Behold, there is a man of God in this city, and he is a man that is held in honour; all that he says comes true. Let us go there; perhaps he can tell us about the journey on which we have set out."

So they went up to the city. As they were entering the city, they saw Samuel coming out toward them on his way up to the high place. Now the day before Saul came, the LORD had revealed to Samuel: "Tomorrow about this time I will send to you a man from the land of Benjamin, and you shall anoint him to be prince over my people Israel. He shall save my people from the hand of the Philistines; for I have seen the affliction of my people, because their cry has come to me." When Samuel saw Saul, the LORD told him, "Here is the man of whom I spoke to you! He it is who shall rule over my people."

Then Saul approached Samuel in the gate, and said, "Tell me where is the house of the seer?" Samuel answered Saul, "I am the seer; go up before me to the high place, for today you shall eat with me, and in the morning I

will let you go and will tell you all that is on your mind. As for your asses that were lost three days ago, do not set your mind on them, for they have been found. And for whom is all that is desirable in Israel? Is it not for you and for all your father's house?" Saul answered, "Am I not a Benjaminite, from the least of the tribes of Israel? And is not my family the humblest of all the families of the tribe of Benjamin? Why then have you spoken to me in this way?"

Then Samuel took Saul and his servant and brought them into the hall and gave them a place at the head of those who had been invited, who were about thirty persons. And Samuel said to the cook, "Bring the portion I gave you, of which I said to you, 'Put it aside.'" So the cook took up the leg and the upper portion and set them before Saul; and Samuel said, "See, what was kept is set before you. Eat; because it was kept for you until the hour appointed, that you might eat with the guests." So Saul ate with Samuel that day.

And when they came down from the high place into the city, a bed was spread for Saul upon the roof, and he lay down to sleep. Then at the break of dawn Samuel called to Saul upon the roof, "Up, that I may send you on your way." So Saul arose, and both he and Samuel went out into the street. As they were going down to the outskirts of the city, Samuel said to Saul, "Tell the servant to pass on before us, and when he has passed on stop here yourself for a while, that I may make known to you the word of God."

Then Samuel took a vial of oil and poured it on his head, and kissed him and said, "Has not the LORD anointed you to be prince over his people Israel? And you shall reign over the people of the LORD and you will save them from the hand of their enemies round about. And this shall be the sign to you that the LORD has anointed you to be prince over his heritage.

Responsorial. *1 Sam. 10: 1; 15: 17*

R: Behold the Lord has anointed you as head over his people Israel. * You will free them from the hands of their enemies.

V: Are you not the head of the tribes of Israel, though small to your own eyes? Has not the Lord perhaps consecrated you king of Israel?

R: You will free them from the hands of their enemies.

Second Reading. *N. 36*

Let us keep vigil during the night, as if it was in full day.

A reading from the treatise “On the Our Father” of St. Cyprian, bishop and martyr.

Let us not, then, who are in Christ — that is, always in the light — cease from praying even during night. Thus the widow Anna, without interruption praying and watching, persevered in deserving well of God, as it is written in the Gospel: “She departed not,” it says, “from the temple, serving God with fasting and prayers night and day.” Let the Gentiles look to this, who are not yet enlightened, or the Jews who have remained in darkness by having forsaken the light. Let us, beloved brethren, who are always in the light of the Lord, who remember and hold fast what by grace received we have begun to be, reckon night for day; let us believe that we always walk in the light, and let us not be hindered by the darkness which we have escaped. Let there be no failure of prayers in the hours of night — no idle and reckless waste of the occasions of prayer. New-created and newborn of the Spirit by the mercy of God, let us imitate what we shall one day be. Since in the kingdom we shall possess day alone, without intervention of night, let us so watch in the night as if in the daylight. Since we are to pray and give thanks to God for ever, let us not cease in this life also to pray and give thanks.

Responsorial. *Lk. 11: 9, 10; Ps. 144: 18*

R: Ask and it will be given to you; * because he who asks receives, he who searches finds, and to him who knocks the door will be opened.

V: The Lord is close to those who invoke him, to those who search for him with a sincere heart.

R: Because he who asks receives, he who searches finds, and to him who knocks the door will be opened.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Neh. 8: 1 – 18*

Ezra makes the first solemn reading of the law to the people.

A reading from the book of Nehemiah.

And all the people gathered as one man into the square before the Water Gate; and they told Ezra the scribe to bring the book of the Law of Moses that the LORD had given to Israel. And Ezra the priest brought the law before the assembly, both men and women and all who could hear with understanding, on the first day of the seventh month.

And he read from it facing the square before the Water Gate from early morning until midday, in the presence of the men and the women and those who could understand; and the ears of all the people were attentive to the book of the law. And Ezra the scribe stood on a wooden pulpit which they had made for the purpose; and beside him stood Mattithi'ah, Shema, Anai'ah, Uri'ah, Hilki'ah, and Ma-asei'ah on his right hand; and Pedai'ah, Mish'a-el, Malchi'jah, Hashum, Hash-bad'danah, Zechari'ah, and Meshul'lam on his left hand.

And Ezra opened the book in the sight of all the people, for he was above all the people; and when he opened it all the people stood. And Ezra blessed the LORD, the great God; and all the people answered, "Amen, Amen," lifting up their hands; and they bowed their heads and worshiped the LORD with their faces to the ground.

Also Jesh'ua, Bani, Sherebi'ah, Jamin, Akkub, Shab'bethai, Hodi'ah, Ma-asei'ah, Keli'ta, Azari'ah, Jo'zabad, Hanan, Pelai'ah, the Levites, helped the people to understand the law, while the people remained in their places.

And they read from the book, from the law of God, clearly; and they gave the sense, so that the people understood the reading. And Nehemi'ah, who was the governor, and Ezra the priest and scribe, and the Levites who taught the people said to all the people, "This day is holy to the LORD your God; do not mourn or weep." For all the people wept when they heard the words of the law. Then he said to them, "Go your way, eat the fat and drink sweet wine and send portions to him for whom nothing is prepared; for this day is holy to our Lord; and do not be grieved, for the joy of the LORD is your strength."

So the Levites stilled all the people, saying, "Be quiet, for this day is holy; do not be grieved." And all the people went their way to eat and drink and to send portions and to make great rejoicing, because they had understood the words that were declared to them. On the second day the heads of fathers' houses of all the people, with the priests and the Levites, came together to Ezra the scribe in order to study the words of the law. And

they found it written in the law that the LORD had commanded by Moses that the people of Israel should dwell in booths during the feast of the seventh month, and that they should publish and proclaim in all their towns and in Jerusalem, "Go out to the hills and bring branches of olive, wild olive, myrtle, palm, and other leafy trees to make booths, as it is written."

So the people went out and brought them and made booths for themselves, each on his roof, and in their courts and in the courts of the house of God, and in the square at the Water Gate and in the square at the Gate of E'phraim. And all the assembly of those who had returned from the captivity made booths and dwelt in the booths; for from the days of Joshua the son of Nun to that day the people of Israel had not done so. And there was very great rejoicing. And day-by-day, from the first day to the last day, he read from the book of the law of God. They kept the feast seven days; and on the eighth day there was a solemn assembly, according to the ordinance.

Responsorial. *Ps. 18: 8-9; Rm. 13: 8, 10*

R: The law of the Lord is perfect, it reassures the soul; the testimony of the Lord is true, it makes the wise simple. * The commands of the Lord are just, they bring joy to the heart; the commands of the Lord are clear, they give light to the eyes.

V: He who loves his neighbour has fulfilled the law. Love is the fulfilment of the law.

R: The commands of the Lord are just, they bring joy to the heart, the commands of the lord are clear, they give light to the eyes.

Second Reading. *Book 1, c. 9*

I am your master.

A reading from "The Pedagogy" of Clement of Alexandria.

Justly the Word is called pedagogue, because he leads us children to salvation. Therefore he has clearly said of himself, by the mouth of Hosea, that he is our protector (cfr. Hos. 11: 1, 3-4).

The divine pedagogy then is the religion: it is contemporarily teaching of the cult of God, education to reach the knowledge of the truth, and good formation that leads to heaven.

The name pedagogy comprises many realities. There is a pedagogy that refers to him who is directed and instructed; and a pedagogy for him who directs and instructs; thirdly the formation itself that is received is a pedagogy; fourthly: the material taught, as for example the commandments is a pedagogy.

As for the pedagogy of God, it is the road of truth to arrive at the contemplation of God, with the clear and evident description of the holy actions that lead to eternal perseverance. As the general guides his ranks trying to save the soldiers and the helmsman directs the ship keeping in mind the salvation of the passengers, so also the Pedagogue brings the children to a tenure of healthy life; that is he takes care of us. In conclusion, all that we can reasonably ask of God, we can obtain by obeying the Pedagogue.

Now, not always the helmsman abandons himself to the winds, but with the prow he affronts the storms; in the same way the pedagogue does not subject the little child to the laws of this world and he does not permit him to be broken like a boat in a bestial and licentious life; but only when the soul of the child is pushed on high by the Spirit of truth, does he hold strongly the helm, that is the internal ear, until when he has made him approach, healthy and safe, to the heavenly door. Because, if the so-called education, which we receive from our fathers finishes soon, the vital formation received from God is a possession that remains forever.

Our holy Pedagogue is Jesus, the Word that is the light of the entire humanity; God himself, who loves men, is our Pedagogue. In the Canticle of Moses the Holy Spirit speaks thus of him: "He found the people in the desert, in a land of wailing desolation. He educated them, he took care of them, he lifted them up, he kept them like the apple of his eye. Like an eagle that keeps watch over its nest, that flies over its newborn, he has spread his wings and has taken them and lifted them up on his wings; the Lord alone led them; there was no foreign God with him" (Deut. 32: 10-11).

In a clear way, I think, the sacred Scriptures show the Pedagogue, indicating the education that he gives us. And again he himself professes himself to be the Pedagogue when he says of himself: "I am the Lord your God, who has brought you out from the country of Egypt" (Ps. 80: 11).

Responsorial. *Prv. 23: 26; 1: 9; 5: 1*

R: Pay attention to me, my son, and keep your gaze fixed on my advice, *
because they will be a gracious crown on your head.

V: My son, pay attention to my wisdom and give ear to my intelligence.

R: because they will be a gracious crown on your head.

Gospel. *Mt. 8: 23 – 27*

Getting up He shouted at the wind and the sea and there was a great calm .

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

And when he got into the boat, his disciples followed him. And behold, there arose a great storm on the sea, so that the boat was being swamped by the waves; but he was asleep. And they went and woke him, saying, "Save us, Lord; we are perishing." And he said to them, "Why are you afraid, O men of little faith?" Then he rose and rebuked the winds and the sea; and there was a great calm. And the men marvelled, saying, "What sort of man is this, that even winds and sea obey him?"

WEDNESDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Sam. 11: 1 – 15*

Saul victor, is acclaimed king of the people.

A reading from the first book of Samuel.

Then Nahash the Ammonite went up and besieged Ja'besh-gil'ead; and all the men of Jabesh said to Nahash, "Make a treaty with us, and we will serve you." But Nahash the Ammonite said to them, "On this condition I will make a treaty with you, that I gouge out all your right eyes, and thus put disgrace upon all Israel." The elders of Jabesh said to him, "Give us

seven days respite that we may send messengers through all the territory of Israel. Then, if there is no one to save us, we will give ourselves up to you."

When the messengers came to Gib'e-ah of Saul, they reported the matter in the ears of the people; and all the people wept aloud. Now Saul was coming from the field behind the oxen; and Saul said, "What ails the people, that they are weeping?" So they told him the tidings of the men of Jabesh. And the spirit of God came mightily upon Saul when he heard these words, and his anger was greatly kindled. He took a yoke of oxen, and cut them in pieces and sent them throughout all the territory of Israel by the hand of messengers, saying, "Whoever does not come out after Saul and Samuel, so shall it be done to his oxen!" Then the dread of the LORD fell upon the people, and they came out as one man.

When he mustered them at Bezek, the men of Israel were three hundred thousand, and the men of Judah thirty thousand. And they said to the messengers who had come, "Thus shall you say to the men of Ja'bish-gil'ead: `Tomorrow, by the time the sun is hot, you shall have deliverance.'"

When the messengers came and told the men of Jabesh, they were glad. Therefore the men of Jabesh said, "Tomorrow we will give ourselves up to you, and you may do to us whatever seems good to you." And on the morrow Saul put the people in three companies; and they came into the midst of the camp in the morning watch, and cut down the Ammonites until the heat of the day; and those who survived were scattered, so that no two of them were left together.

Then the people said to Samuel, "Who is it that said, `Shall Saul reign over us?' Bring the men, that we may put them to death." But Saul said, "Not a man shall be put to death this day, for today the LORD has wrought deliverance in Israel." Then Samuel said to the people, "Come, let us go to Gilgal and there renew the kingdom." So all the people went to Gilgal, and there they made Saul king before the LORD in Gilgal. There they sacrificed peace offerings before the LORD, and there Saul and all the men of Israel rejoiced greatly.

Responsorial. *Ps. 17: 47, 49, 51*

R: May the Lord my rock be blessed and live forever, may the God of my salvation be exalted. * You have saved me from furious enemies.

V: he grants great victories to his king, he shows himself faithful to his consecrated.

R: You have saved me from furious enemies.

Second Reading. Ps. 149: 6

Christ is the king and the priest: in him we exult.

A reading from the “Commentary on the psalms” of St. Augustine, bishop.

“Israel rejoices in its Creator, the children of Zion exult in their King” (Ps. 149: 2). The Son of God who created us, has become one of us; our king governs us, because he is our Creator who has made us. He then is the one for whom we have been made, and he is the one by whom we are governed; for this we are called Christians, by him who is the Christ.

The name Christ comes from the chrism that is from the anointing. But the priests and the kings were anointed: he therefore is anointed King and Priest. As king, he fights for us, as priest, he offered himself for us. When he fought for us he was almost overcome; but in reality he overcame. In fact he was crucified, but it was exactly from the cross on which he was crucified that he killed the devil: therefore he is our king.

But why is he priest? Because he offered himself for us. You give to the priest that which he has to offer. What could man have found to present as a pure victim? Which victim? What pure thing can the sinner offer? O iniquitous, O impious! Whatever you bring is impure, while he has to offer something pure for you. Search in yourself for what you can offer, you will not find it. Search among that which is yours for what you can offer: he does not like rams, nor goats, or bulls. All things are his, even if you do not offer them to him. Offer therefore a pure sacrifice to him. But you are a sinner, you are impious, you have a stained conscience. You could perhaps offer something pure when you will be purified; but so that you may be purified, you have to offer something for yourself.

What therefore will you offer for yourself, in order to be cleansed? If you were purified, you could offer a pure gift. A pure priest offers therefore himself, and fulfils in this way the purification. This is what Christ did. Nothing pure was found in men to offer for men; he offered himself as a pure victim. Blessed victim, true victim, immaculate host! He, in fact, did not offer something given by us, but that which he had assumed from us and had offered pure. From us he had received the flesh and this he offered. But from where did he take it? From the womb of the Virgin Mary, in order to

offer it pure for the sinners. He therefore is the king, the priest: in him we exult.

Responsorial. *Ap. 12: 10, 12; 11: 15*

R: Now has been accomplished the salvation, the strength and the kingdom of our God and the power of his Christ. * Exult therefore, O heavens, and you that dwell in it.

V: the kingdom of the world belongs to our Lord and to his Christ.

R: Exult therefore, O heavens, and you that dwell in it.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Neh. 9: 1 – 2, 5 – 21*

Penitential liturgy. Prayer of the Levites.

A reading from the book of Nehemiah.

Now on the twenty-fourth day of this month the people of Israel were assembled with fasting and in sackcloth, and with earth upon their heads. And the Israelites separated themselves from all foreigners, and stood and confessed their sins and the iniquities of their fathers.

Then the Levites, Jeshua, Kad'mi-el, Bani, Hashabnei'ah, Sherebi'ah, Hodi'ah, Shebani'ah, and Pethahi'ah, said, "Stand up and bless the LORD your God from everlasting to everlasting. Blessed be your glorious name which is exalted above all blessing and praise." And Ezra said: "You are the LORD, you alone; you have made heaven, the heaven of heavens, with all their host, the earth and all that is on it, the seas and all that is in them; and you preserve all of them; and the host of heaven worships you. You are the LORD, the God who chose Abram and brought him forth out of Ur of the Chalde'ans and gave him the name Abraham; and you did find his heart faithful before you, and did make with him the covenant to give to his descendants the land of the Canaanite, the Hittite, the Amorite, the Per'izzite, the Jeb'usite, and the Gir'gashite; and you have fulfilled your promise, for you are righteous. "And you did see the affliction of our fathers in Egypt and hear their cry at the Red Sea, and did perform signs and

wonders against Pharaoh and all his servants and all the people of his land, for you knew that they acted insolently against our fathers; and you did get for yourself a name, as it is to this day. And you did divide the sea before them, so that they went through the midst of the sea on dry land; and you did cast their pursuers into the depths, as a stone into mighty waters. By a pillar of cloud you did lead them in the day, and by a pillar of fire in the night to light for them the way in which they should go. You did come down upon Mount Sinai, and speak with them from heaven and give them right ordinances and true laws, good statutes and commandments, and you did make known to them your holy Sabbath and command them commandments and statutes and a law by Moses your servant. You did give them bread from heaven for their hunger and bring forth water for them from the rock for their thirst, and you did tell them to go in to possess the land that you had sworn to give them.

"But they and our fathers acted presumptuously and stiffened their neck and did not obey your commandments; they refused to obey, and were not mindful of the wonders which you did perform among them; but they stiffened their neck and appointed a leader to return to their bondage in Egypt. But you are a God ready to forgive, gracious and merciful, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love, and did not forsake them. Even when they had made for themselves a molten calf and said, 'This is your God who brought you up out of Egypt,' and had committed great blasphemies, you in your great mercies did not forsake them in the wilderness; the pillar of cloud which led them in the way did not depart from them by day, nor the pillar of fire by night which lighted for them the way by which they should go.

You gave your good Spirit to instruct them, and did not withhold your manna from their mouth, and gave them water for their thirst. Forty years did you sustain them in the wilderness, and they lacked nothing; their clothes did not wear out and their feet did not swell.

Responsorial. *Ne. 9: 1, 2, 16-17*

R: The Israelites gathered together for a fast, clothed in sackcloth and covered with dust, and they confessed their sins and the iniquities of their fathers. * But you are a God who is ready to forgive, compassionate and merciful and you did not abandon them.

V: Our fathers behaved with pride, they refused to obey and they did not remember the miracles that you had worked in their favour.

R: But you are a God who is ready to forgive, compassionate and merciful and you did not abandon them.

Second Reading. Nm . 12 – 14

Christ gives us peace and orders us to be only one heart and one soul.

A reading from the treatise “On the unity of the Catholic Church” of St. Cyprian, bishop and martyr.

For the Lord, when He would urge unanimity and peace upon His disciples, said, “I say unto you, that if two of you shall agree on earth regarding anything that you shall ask, it shall be given you by my Father who is in heaven. For wherever two or three are gathered together in my name, I am with them;” showing that most is given, not to the multitude, but to the unanimity of those that pray. “If,” He says, “two of you shall agree on earth:” He placed agreement first; He has made the concord of peace a prerequisite; He taught that we should agree firmly and faithfully. But how can he agree with any one who does not agree with the body of the Church itself, and with the universal brotherhood? How can two or three be assembled together in Christ’s name, when it is evident, that they are separated from Christ and from His Gospel? For we have not withdrawn from them, but they from us; and since heresies and schisms have risen subsequently, from their establishment for themselves of diverse places of worship, they have forsaken the Head and Source of the truth.

But the Lord speaks concerning His Church, and to those also who are in the Church He speaks, that if they are in agreement, if according to what He commanded and admonished, although only two or three gathered together with unanimity should pray — though they be only two or three — they may obtain from the majesty of God what they ask. “Wherever two or three are gathered together in my name, I,” says He, “am with them;” that is, with the simple and peaceable — with those who fear God and keep God’s commandments. With these, although only two or three, He said that He was, in the same manner as He was with the three youths in the fiery furnace; and because they abode towards God in simplicity, and in

unanimity among themselves, He animated them, in the midst of the surrounding flames, with the breath of dew: in the way in which, with the two apostles shut up in prison, because they were simple-minded and of one mind, He Himself was present; He Himself, having loosed the bolts of the dungeon, placed them again in the market-place, that they might declare to the multitude the word which they faithfully preached. When, therefore, in His commandments He lays it down, and says, "Where two or three are gathered together in my name, I am with them," He does not divide men from the Church, seeing that He Himself ordained and made the Church; but rebuking the faithless for their discord, and commending peace by His word to the faithful, He shows that He is rather with two or three who pray with one mind, than with a great many who differ, and that more can be obtained by the concordant prayer of a few, than by the concordant supplication of many.

Thus, also, when He gave the law of prayer, He added, saying, "And when you stand praying, forgive, if you have anything against anyone; that your Father also who is in heaven may forgive you your trespasses." And He calls back from the altar one that comes to the sacrifice in strife, and bids him first agree with his brother, and then return with peace and offer his gift to God.

Christ left us peace, he commanded us to remain united and harmonious in sentiments, he ordered us to maintain the laws of love incorruptible and inviolate.

Responsorial. *Mt. 18: 19-20; 2 Cor. 7: 15*

R: If two of you on the earth agree to ask anything, my Father who is in heaven will grant it to you. * Because where there are two or three united in my name, I am in their midst.

V: Now my eyes are opened and my ears are attentive to the prayer made in this place.

R: Because where there are two or three united in my name, I am in their midst.

Gospel. *Mt. 8: 28 – 34*

Have you come here before the time to torment us.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

And when he came to the other side, to the country of the Gadarenes, two demoniacs met him, coming out of the tombs, so fierce that no one could pass that way. And behold, they cried out, "What have you to do with us, O Son of God? Have you come here to torment us before the time?"

Now a herd of many swine was feeding at some distance from them. And the demons begged him, "If you cast us out, send us away into the herd of swine." And he said to them, "Go." So they came out and went into the swine; and behold, the whole herd rushed down the steep bank into the sea, and perished in the waters. The herdsmen fled, and going into the city they told everything, and what had happened to the demoniacs. And behold, the entire city came out to meet Jesus; and when they saw him, they begged him to leave their neighbourhood.

THURSDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Sam. 12: 1 – 25*

Samuel admonishes the people.

A reading from the first book of Samuel.

And Samuel said to all Israel, "Behold, I have hearkened to your voice in all that you have said to me, and have made a king over you. And now, behold, the king walks before you; and I am old and grey, and behold, my sons are with you; and I have walked before you from my youth until this day. Here I am; testify against me before the LORD and before his anointed. Whose ox have I taken? Or whose ass have I taken? Or whom

have I defrauded? Whom have I oppressed? Or from whose hand have I taken a bribe to blind my eyes with it? Testify against me and I will restore it to you."

They said, "You have not defrauded us or oppressed us or taken anything from any man's hand." And he said to them, "The LORD is witness against you, and his anointed is witness this day, that you have not found anything in my hand." And they said, "He is witness."

And Samuel said to the people, "The LORD is witness, who appointed Moses and Aaron and brought your fathers up out of the land of Egypt. Now therefore stand still, that I may plead with you before the LORD concerning all the saving deeds of the LORD that he performed for you and for your fathers. When Jacob went into Egypt and the Egyptians oppressed them, then your fathers cried to the LORD and the LORD sent Moses and Aaron, who brought forth your fathers out of Egypt, and made them dwell in this place. But they forgot the LORD their God; and he sold them into the hand of Sis'era, commander of the army of Jabin king of Hazor, and into the hand of the Philistines, and into the hand of the king of Moab; and they fought against them. And they cried to the LORD, and said, 'We have sinned, because we have forsaken the LORD, and have served the Ba'als and the Ash'taroth; but now deliver us out of the hand of our enemies, and we will serve you.' And the LORD sent Jerubba'al and Barak, and Jephthah, and Samuel, and delivered you out of the hand of your enemies on every side; and you dwelt in safety. And when you saw that Nahash the king of the Ammonites came against you, you said to me, 'No, but a king shall reign over us,' when the LORD your God was your king. And now behold the king whom you have chosen, for whom you have asked; behold, the LORD has set a king over you. If you will fear the LORD and serve him and hearken to his voice and not rebel against the commandment of the LORD, and if both you and the king who reigns over you will follow the LORD your God, it will be well; but if you will not hearken to the voice of the LORD, but rebel against the commandment of the LORD, then the hand of the LORD will be against you and your king. Now therefore stand still and see this great thing, which the LORD will do before your eyes. Is it not wheat harvest today? I will call upon the LORD, that he may send thunder and rain; and you shall know and see that your wickedness is great, which you have done in the sight of the LORD, in asking for yourselves a king."

So Samuel called upon the LORD, and the LORD sent thunder and rain that day; and all the people greatly feared the LORD and Samuel.

And all the people said to Samuel, "Pray for your servants to the LORD your God, that we may not die; for we have added to all our sins this evil, to ask for ourselves a king."

And Samuel said to the people, "Fear not; you have done all this evil, yet do not turn aside from following the LORD, but serve the LORD with all your heart; and do not turn aside after vain things which cannot profit or save, for they are vain. For the LORD will not cast away his people, for his great name's sake, because it has pleased the LORD to make you a people for himself. Moreover as for me, far be it from me that I should sin against the LORD by ceasing to pray for you; and I will instruct you in the good and the right way. Only fear the LORD, and serve him faithfully with all your heart; for consider what great things he has done for you. But if you still do wickedly, you shall be swept away, both you and your king."

Responsorial. *1 Sam. 12: 20, 22*

R: Samuel answered the people: You have done all this evil; but at least in the future do not go far away from the Lord. * Serve him, the Lord, with all your heart.

V: Certainly the Lord will not abandon his people, out of regard for his name that is great, because the Lord has begun to make of you his people.

R: Serve him, the Lord, with all your heart.

Second Reading. *Part 1, c. 3*

The weight of government.

A reading from the "Pastoral rule" of St. Gregory the Great, pope.

So much, then, have we briefly said, to show how great is the weight of government, lest whosoever is unequal to sacred offices of government should dare to profane them, and through lust of pre-eminence undertake a leadership of perdition.

For hence it is that James affectionately deters us, saying, Not many of you should presume to be teachers my brothers (James 3:1). Hence the Mediator between God and man Himself — He who, transcending the knowledge and understanding even of supernatural spirits, reigns in heaven from eternity-on earth fled from receiving a kingdom. For it is written, When Jesus therefore perceived that they would come and take Him by force, to make Him a king, He departed again into the mountain by Himself (Jn 6:15).

For who could so blamelessly have had principality over men as He who would in fact have reigned over those whom He had Himself created?

But, because He had come in the flesh to this end, that He might not only redeem us by His passion but also teach us by His conversation, offering Himself as an example to His followers, He would not be made a king; but He went of His own accord to the gibbet of the cross. He fled from the offered glory of pre-eminence, but desired the pain of an ignominious death; that so His members might learn to fly from the favours of the world, to be afraid of no terrors, to love adversity for the truth's sake, and to shrink in fear from prosperity; because this often defiles the heart through vain glory, while that purges it through sorrow; in this the mind exalts itself, but in that, even though it had once exalted itself, it brings itself low; in this man forgets himself, but in that, even perforce and against his will, he is recalled to memory of what he is; in this even good things done aforetime often come to nothing, but in that faults even of long standing are wiped away. For commonly in the school of adversity the heart is subdued under discipline, while, on sudden attainment of supreme rule, it is forthwith changed and becomes elated through familiarity with glory. Thus Saul, who had before fled in consideration of his unworthiness, no sooner had assumed the government of the kingdom than he was puffed up (1 Kings 10:22; 15:17, 30); for, desirous of being honoured before the people while unwilling to be publicly blamed, he cut off from himself even him who had anointed him to the kingdom. Thus David, who in the judgment of Him who chose him was well pleasing to Him in almost all his deeds, as soon as the weight of pressure was removed, broke out into a swelling sore (2 Kings 11:3, seq.), and, having been as a laxly running one in his appetite for the woman, became as a cruelly hard one in the slaughter of the man; and he who had before known pitifully how to spare the bad

learnt afterwards, without impediment of hesitation, to pant even for the death of the good (Ibid. 15).

For, indeed, previously he had been unwilling to smite his captured persecutor; and afterwards, with loss to his wearied army, he destroyed even his devoted soldier. And in truth his crime would have snatched him farther away from the number of the elect, had not scourges called him back to pardon.

Responsorial. *Lk. 12: 48; Wis. 6: 6*

R: From everyone who has been given much, much will be demanded; * and from the one who has been entrusted with much, much more will be asked.

V: The powerful will be examined with severity:

R: and from the one who has been entrusted with much, much more will be asked.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Neh. 9:22 – 36*

Prayer of the Levites.

A reading from the book of Nehemiah.

And you did give them kingdoms and peoples, and did allot to them every corner; so they took possession of the land of Sihon king of Heshbon and the land of Og king of Bashan.

You did multiply their descendants as the stars of heaven, and you did bring them into the land that you had told their fathers to enter and possess. So the descendants went in and possessed the land, and you did subdue before them the inhabitants of the land, the Canaanites, and did give them into their hands, with their kings and the peoples of the land, that they might do with them as they would. And they captured fortified cities and a rich land, and took possession of houses full of all good things, cisterns hewn out, vineyards, olive orchards and fruit trees in abundance; so they ate, and were filled and became fat, and delighted themselves in your great goodness. "Nevertheless they were disobedient and rebelled against you and cast your law behind their back and killed your prophets, who had warned

them in order to turn them back to you, and they committed great blasphemies. Therefore you did give them into the hand of their enemies, who made them suffer; and in the time of their suffering they cried to you and you did hear them from heaven; and according to your great mercies you did give them saviours who saved them from the hand of their enemies. But after they had rest they did evil again before you, and you did abandon them to the hand of their enemies, so that they had dominion over them; yet when they turned and cried to you, you did hear from heaven, and many times you did deliver them according to your mercies. And you did warn them in order to turn them back to your law. Yet they acted presumptuously and did not obey your commandments, but sinned against your ordinances, by the observance of which a man shall live, and turned a stubborn shoulder and stiffened their neck and would not obey.

Many years you did bear with them, and did warn them by your Spirit through your prophets; yet they would not give ear. Therefore you did give them into the hand of the peoples of the lands. Nevertheless in your great mercies you did not make an end of them or forsake them; for you are a gracious and merciful God. "Now therefore, our God, the great and mighty and terrible God, who keeps covenant and steadfast love, let not all the hardship seem little to you that has come upon us, upon our kings, our princes, our priests, our prophets, our fathers, and all your people, since the time of the kings of Assyria until this day.

Yet you have been just in all that has come upon us, for you have dealt faithfully and we have acted wickedly; our kings, our princes, our priests, and our fathers have not kept your law or heeded your commandments and your warnings that you did give them. They did not serve you in their kingdom, and in your great goodness that you gave them, and in the large and rich land that you did set before them; and they did not turn from their wicked works.

Behold, we are slaves this day; in the land that you gave to our fathers to enjoy its fruit and its good gifts, behold, we are slaves.

Responsorial. *Neh. 9: 4, 26, 32, 33*

R: The Levites invoked the Lord in a loud voice: Our fathers have been disobedient, they have rebelled against you and they have cast your laws behind their backs: * Now, our God, great God, powerful and tremendous,

who maintains his covenant and mercy, let the misfortune that has crashed down on us not be a small thing in your eyes.

V: You have been just in all that you have done to us, because you have acted faithfully, while we have behaved with wickedness.

R: Now, our God, great God, powerful and tremendous, who maintains his covenant and mercy, let the misfortune that has crashed down on us not be a small thing in your eyes.

Second Reading. *Book 7, c. 7*

For the whole life we must adore God.

A reading from the book of the Stromata” of St. Clement of Alexandria.

Now we are commanded to reverence and to honour the same one, being persuaded that He is Word, Saviour, and Leader, and by Him, the Father, not on special days, as some others, but doing this continually in our whole life, and in every way.

Certainly the elect race justified by the precept says, “Seven times a day have I praised You.” For this not in a specified place, or selected temple, or at certain festivals and on appointed days, but during his whole life, in every place, even if he be alone by himself, and wherever he has any of those who have exercised the same faith, honours God, that is, acknowledges his gratitude for the knowledge of the way to live.

And if the presence of a good man, through the respect and reverence which he inspires, always improves him with whom he associates, with much more reason does not he who always holds uninterrupted converse with God by knowledge, life, and thanksgiving, grow at every step superior to himself in all respects — in conduct, in words, in disposition?

Such a one is persuaded that God is ever beside him, and does not suppose that He is confined in certain limited places; so that under the idea that at times he is without Him, he may indulge in excesses night and day. Holding festival, then, in our whole life, persuaded that God is altogether on every side present, we cultivate our fields, praising; we sail the sea, singing hymns; in all the rest of our conversation we conduct ourselves according to rule. He who knows God, then, is very closely allied to God, being at once grave and cheerful in all things, — grave on account of the bent of his soul

towards the Divinity, and cheerful on account of his consideration of the blessings of humanity which God has given us.

And yet it is not useless to pray, even though the goods are given to us even without our asking for them. But the thanksgiving and the request of that which serves for the conversion of the neighbour, are the task of the one who knows God. With the same scope the Lord prayed, giving thanks for having brought to its end his ministry and asking that as many as possible could reach the knowledge; so that those who were saved could glorify God for their salvation, and he who is the only good and the only saviour could be known forever and ever through the Son. Besides the faith also with which one believes that he will receive that which he asks for, is a form of prayer that is placed in the heart by the knowledge of God.

For the rest, if the prayer is an occasion to converse with God, no occasion to draw near to him should be lost. Certainly the holiness of the one who knows God, connected with the blessed providence, manifests with spontaneous confession the perfect gift of God. God does not accomplish good things out of necessity, but through free will he does good to those who convert to him. The divine providence does not come to us in a servile way, as if it was proceeding from an inferior to a superior; but out of mercy towards our weakness the gifts of providence are continuously lavished on us, as the shepherd with the sheep, or the king with those who obey him, and we towards our superiors, who rule those who are entrusted to them in a way that God wanted.

Those who render cult and free submission as to a great king are therefore servants and adorers of God, and this comes about through an honest mentality and knowledge.

Responsorial. *Lk. 11: 9, 10; Ps. 144: 18*

R: Ask and it will be given to you * because he who asks will receive, he who searches finds, and to him who knocks the door will be opened.

V: The Lord is near to those who invoke him with a sincere heart;

R: because he who asks will receive, he who searches finds, and to him who knocks the door will be opened.

Gospel. *Mt. 9: 1 – 8*

They gave glory to God who had given such power to a man.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

And getting into a boat he crossed over and came to his own city. And behold, they brought to him a paralytic, lying on his bed; and when Jesus saw their faith he said to the paralytic, "Take heart, my son; your sins are forgiven." And behold, some of the scribes said to themselves, "This man is blaspheming." But Jesus, knowing their thoughts, said, "Why do you think evil in your hearts? For which is easier, to say, 'Your sins are forgiven,' or to say, 'Rise and walk'? But that you may know that the Son of man has authority on earth to forgive sins" -- he then said to the paralytic -- "Rise, take up your bed and go home." And he rose and went home. When the crowds saw it, they were afraid, and they glorified God, who had given such authority to men.

FRIDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Sam. 15: 1 – 23*

The Lord rejects Saul because of his sin.

A reading from the first book of Samuel.

And Samuel said to Saul, "The LORD sent me to anoint you king over his people Israel; now therefore hearken to the words of the LORD. Thus says the LORD of hosts, 'I will punish what Am'alek did to Israel in opposing them on the way, when they came up out of Egypt. Now go and smite Am'alek, and utterly destroy all that they have; do not spare them, but kill both man and woman, infant and suckling, ox and sheep, camel and ass.'" So Saul summoned the people, and numbered them in Tela'im, two hundred thousand men on foot, and ten thousand men of Judah. And Saul came to the city of Am'alek, and lay in wait in the valley. And Saul said to the Ken'ites, "Go, depart, go down from among the Amal'ekites, lest I destroy you with them; for you showed kindness to all the people of Israel when they came up out of Egypt." So the Ken'ites departed from among the Amal'ekites. And Saul defeated the Amal'ekites, from Hav'ilah as far as

Shur, which is east of Egypt. And he took Agag the king of the Amal'ekites alive, and utterly destroyed all the people with the edge of the sword. But Saul and the people spared Agag, and the best of the sheep and of the oxen and of the fatlings, and the lambs, and all that was good, and would not utterly destroy them; all that was despised and worthless they utterly destroyed.

The word of the LORD came to Samuel: "I repent that I have made Saul king; for he has turned back from following me, and has not performed my commandments." And Samuel was angry; and he cried to the LORD all night. And Samuel rose early to meet Saul in the morning; and it was told Samuel, "Saul came to Carmel, and behold, he set up a monument for himself and turned, and passed on, and went down to Gilgal." And Samuel came to Saul, and Saul said to him, "Blessed be you to the LORD; I have performed the commandment of the LORD." And Samuel said, "What then is this bleating of the sheep in my ears, and the lowing of the oxen which I hear?" Saul said, "They have brought them from the Amal'ekites; for the people spared the best of the sheep and of the oxen, to sacrifice to the LORD your God; and the rest we have utterly destroyed." Then Samuel said to Saul, "Stop! I will tell you what the LORD said to me this night." And he said to him, "Say on."

And Samuel said, "Though you are little in your own eyes, are you not the head of the tribes of Israel? The LORD anointed you king over Israel. And the LORD sent you on a mission, and said, 'Go, utterly destroy the sinners, the Amal'ekites, and fight against them until they are consumed.' Why then did you not obey the voice of the LORD? Why did you swoop on the spoil, and do what was evil in the sight of the LORD?" And Saul said to Samuel, "I have obeyed the voice of the LORD, I have gone on the mission on which the LORD sent me, I have brought Agag the king of Am'alek, and I have utterly destroyed the Amal'ekites. But the people took of the spoil, sheep and oxen, the best of the things devoted to destruction, to sacrifice to the LORD your God in Gilgal."

And Samuel said, "Has the LORD as great delight in burnt offerings and sacrifices, as in obeying the voice of the LORD? Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice, and to hearken than the fat of rams. For rebellion is as the sin of divination, and stubbornness is as iniquity and idolatry. Because you have rejected the word of the LORD, he has also rejected you from being king."

Responsorial. *1 Sam. 15: 22; Hos. 6: 6*

R: Has the Lord as great delight in burnt offerings and sacrifices, as in obeying the voice of the Lord? * Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice, and to hearken than the fat of rams.

V: I want love and not sacrifice, the knowledge of God more than holocausts.

R: Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice, and to hearken than the fat of rams.

Second Reading. *Cat. 2:5 – 8*

The salvation comes from the mercy of God.

A reading from the “Catechesis” of St. Cyril of Jerusalem, bishop.

He who shed his blood for us, is precisely the one who has freed us from sin. Let us not despair of ourselves, brothers, in order not to fall into a state of desolation without hope. It is a terrible thing not to have the hope of conversion. He who does not await salvation accumulates evil without measure: he instead who hopes to be healed, easily controls himself for the future. The bandit who does not await forgiveness anymore proceeds in his faults; if instead he hopes in forgiveness, he turns to penance. Even the serpent can put aside the old skin, and should we not put aside sin?

The Lord is benevolent, and he is so without measure. You therefore be careful not to say: I have been dissolute and adulterous, I have accomplished wicked actions, and not only once, but often: do you still want to forgive me? And is it possible that you do not remember them anymore? Listen to what the psalmist says: “How great is your goodness, Lord” (Ps. 30: 20). The heap of your sins does not surpass the greatness of the mercy of God, your wounds do not surpass the experience of the great doctor. Only hand yourself over to him with faith, confess to the doctor your sickness, say also like David: “I said: I will confess my faults to the Lord” and let that which follows immediately happen in you: “and you have forgiven the malice of my sin” (Ps. 31: 5).

Do you desire to see the benevolence of God and his boundless generosity? Listen to what happened to Adam. He was the first man created by God and he disobeyed his command: could he not have killed him in that same moment? But see what the Lord who loves men infinitely did. He cast

him out of paradise and he placed him out of it, so that, seeing the place from which he had fallen and from which reality into which other he had been thrown, he could be saved again through penance.

This is the goodness of God; but in comparison to the benefits that follow this is a very small thing. Remember what happened at the time of Noah. The giants sinned, and that was the evil that was diffused on the earth in that time, which caused the flood. But do you not see also in this the goodness of God who was patient for hundred years?

Could he not have done immediately what he did after hundred years? But he purposely lengthened the time, in order to give them time to repent. Do you see the goodness of God? Not even those, if then they had done penance, would have been deprived of his benevolence.

Responsorial. *Jdt. 8: 20, 17*

R: We do not recognise any God other than Him and for this we hope * he will not neglect our nation or us.

V: We await with faith the salvation that comes from him and we beg him to come to our help:

R: he will not neglect our nation or us.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Neh. 12: 27 – 47*

Dedication of the wall of Jerusalem.

A reading from the book of Nehemiah.

And at the dedication of the wall of Jerusalem they sought the Levites in all their places, to bring them to Jerusalem to celebrate the dedication with gladness, with thanksgivings and with singing, with cymbals, harps, and lyres. And the sons of the singers gathered together from the circuit round Jerusalem and from the villages of the Netoph'athites; also from Beth-gilgal and from the region of Geba and Az'maveth; for the singers had built for themselves villages around Jerusalem.

And the priests and the Levites purified themselves; and they purified the people and the gates and the wall. Then I brought up the princes of Judah upon the wall, and appointed two great companies that gave thanks

and went in procession. One went to the right upon the wall to the Dung Gate; and after them went Hoshai'ah and half of the princes of Judah, and Azari'ah, Ezra, Meshul'lam, Judah, Benjamin, Shemai'ah, and Jeremiah, and certain of the priests' sons with trumpets: Zechari'ah the son of Jonathan, son of Shemai'ah, son of Mattani'ah, son of Micai'ah, son of Zaccur, son of Asaph; and his kinsmen, Shemai'ah, Az'arel, Mil'alai, Gil'alai, Ma'ai, Nethan'el, Judah, and Hana'ni, with the musical instruments of David the man of God; and Ezra the scribe went before them. At the Fountain Gate they went up straight before them by the stairs of the city of David, at the ascent of the wall, above the house of David, to the Water Gate on the east.

The other company of those who gave thanks went to the left, and I followed them with half of the people, upon the wall, above the Tower of the Ovens, to the Broad Wall, and above the Gate of E'phraim, and by the Old Gate, and by the Fish Gate and the Tower of Hanan'el and the Tower of the Hundred, to the Sheep Gate; and they came to a halt at the Gate of the Guard. So both companies of those who gave thanks stood in the house of God, and I and half of the officials with me; and the priests Eli'akim, Ma-asei'ah, Mini'amin, Micai'ah, Eli-o-e'nai, Zechari'ah, and Hanani'ah, with trumpets; and Ma-asei'ah, Shemai'ah, Elea'zar, Uzzi, Jehoha'nan, Malchi'jah, Elam, and Ezer. And the singers sang with Jezrahi'ah as their leader. And they offered great sacrifices that day and rejoiced, for God had made them rejoice with great joy; the women and children also rejoiced. And the joy of Jerusalem was heard afar off.

On that day men were appointed over the chambers for the stores, the contributions, the first fruits, and the tithes, to gather into them the portions required by the law for the priests and for the Levites according to the fields of the towns; for Judah rejoiced over the priests and the Levites who ministered. And they performed the service of their God and the service of purification, as did the singers and the gatekeepers, according to the command of David and his son Solomon. For in the days of David and Asaph of old there was a chief of the singers, and there were songs of praise and thanksgiving to God. And all Israel in the days of Zerub'babel and in the days of Nehemi'ah gave the daily portions for the singers and the gatekeepers; and they set apart that which was for the Levites; and the Levites set apart that which was for the sons of Aaron.

Responsorial. *Is. 26: 1; Ps. 47: 3*

R: We have a strong city. * He has erected wall and bulwark for our salvation.

V: Mount Sion, stupendous high ground, is the joy of all the earth: it is the city of the great sovereign.

R: He has erected wall and bulwark for our salvation.

Second Reading. *Ps. 47: 16 – 17*

He Himself founded the Church.

A reading from the “Commentary on the psalms” of St. Ambrose, bishop

We have received, O God, your mercy, inside your temple (cfr. Ps. 47: 10). If the Son of God is called the temple of God, it is in the sense in which he spoke of his body: “I will destroy this temple and in three days I will make it rise again” (Jn. 2: 19). **The body of Christ is truly the temple of God in which the purification of our sins takes place. That flesh which sin could not contaminate, but which was the victim for the misdeeds of the whole world, is truly the temple of God.**

That flesh in which the image of God shone forth is truly the temple of God and in it the fullness of divinity lived physically. Christ himself in fact is the fullness. For this to him is said: We have received, O God, your mercy inside your temple (cfr. Ps. 47: 10).

And what does that mean if not this: “In the midst of you is one whom you do not know” (Jn. 1: 26). He is in the midst of you and you do not see him. If he is referring to the Father, what does it mean “in the midst of your temple”; if not that God was in Christ in order to reconcile the world to himself? In that temple, we have received your mercy, which is the Word made flesh that lived amongst us. As Christ is the redemption, so also he is mercy. **What greater mercy is there than to offer himself as a victim for our sins in order to purify with his blood the world, whose sins could not have been destroyed in any other way?**

If speaking of the saints the Apostle says: “You are the temple of God and the Spirit of God dwells in you” (1 Cor. 3: 16), how much more will the humanity of the Lord Jesus, who was always full of the Holy Spirit, be called the temple of God, as he himself gave witness saying: “I felt a power coming out of me” (Lk. 8: 46): it was that power that healed the painful wounds of all.

Having spoken of having received with the people the mercy of God in his temple, it can be also understood in the sense that he founded his Church and spread it in eternity; because God truly conferred this grace to his people through his Only begotten Son, and he indicated him also as constructor, saying: "He will build a house for my name" (2 Sam. 7: 13); which, diffused in the whole world, will fill the earth with his praise and with his name. Thus it is written in fact: "The earth is full of your praise" (Hab. 3: 3); and again: "God has given him the name that is above all other names; because in the name of Jesus every knee will bend in the heavens, on the earth and in the underworld; and every tongue will proclaim that Jesus Christ is the Lord, for the glory of God the Father" (Phil. 2: 9-11).

Responsorial. *Is. 33: 20, 21*

R: See Zion, the city of our feasts! Your eyes will see Jerusalem, tranquil dwelling, tent that will never be removed. * Because there, there is a powerful one: the Lord.

V: Its pegs will not be pulled up, none of its cords will be torn up.

R: Because there, there is the powerful one: the Lord.

Gospel. *Mt. 9: 9 – 13*

It is not the healthy who need the doctor. I want mercy and not sacrifice.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

As Jesus passed on from there, he saw a man called Matthew sitting at the tax office; and he said to him, "Follow me." And he rose and followed him. And as he sat at table in the house, behold, many tax collectors and sinners came and sat down with Jesus and his disciples. And when the Pharisees saw this, they said to his disciples, "Why does your teacher eat with tax collectors and sinners?" But when he heard it, he said, "Those who are well have no need of a physician, but those who are sick. Go and learn

what this means, 'I desire mercy, and not sacrifice.' For I came not to call the righteous, but sinners."

SATURDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1Sam. 16: 1 – 13*

David is consecrated king.

A reading from the first book of Samuel.

The LORD said to Samuel, "How long will you grieve over Saul, seeing I have rejected him from being king over Israel? Fill your horn with oil, and go; I will send you to Jesse the Bethlehemite, for I have provided for myself a king among his sons." And Samuel said, "How can I go? If Saul hears it, he will kill me." And the LORD said, "Take a heifer with you, and say, 'I have come to sacrifice to the LORD.' And invite Jesse to the sacrifice, and I will show you what you shall do; and you shall anoint for me him whom I name to you." Samuel did what the LORD commanded, and came to Bethlehem. The elders of the city came to meet him trembling, and said, "Do you come peaceably?" And he said, "Peaceably; I have come to sacrifice to the LORD; consecrate yourselves, and come with me to the sacrifice." And he consecrated Jesse and his sons, and invited them to the sacrifice. When they came, he looked on Eli'ab and thought, "Surely the LORD'S anointed is before him." But the LORD said to Samuel, "Do not look on his appearance or on the height of his stature, because I have rejected him; for the LORD sees not as man sees; man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart." Then Jesse called Abin'adab, and made him pass before Samuel. And he said, "Neither has the LORD chosen this one." Then Jesse made Shammah pass by. And he said, "Neither has the LORD chosen this one." And Jesse made seven of his sons pass before Samuel. And Samuel said to Jesse, "The LORD has not chosen these." And Samuel said to Jesse, "Are all your sons here?" And he said, "There remains yet the youngest, but behold, he is keeping the sheep." And Samuel said to Jesse, "Send and fetch him; for we will not sit down till he comes here." And he sent, and brought him in. Now he was ruddy, and had

beautiful eyes, and was handsome. And the LORD said, "Arise, anoint him; for this is he." Then Samuel took the horn of oil, and anointed him in the midst of his brothers; and the Spirit of the LORD came mightily upon David from that day forward. And Samuel rose up, and went to Ramah.

Responsorial. *Ps. 88: 20, 22, 21*

R: I have brought help to a valiant man, I have raised up an elected one among my people. * My hand will sustain him.

V: "I have found David, my servant, with my holy oil I have consecrated him".

R: My hand will sustain him

Second Reading. *Nm. 30 – 40*

Christ king and priest in eternity.

A reading from the treatise "On the Trinity" of Faustino Luciferiano, priest.

Our saviour was truly made the Anointed One according to the flesh, becoming true king and true priest. He was both so that nothing might be lacking in the Saviour. Notice therefore that he became king, when he says: 'I was set by the Lord as king on Zion, his holy mountain'. Learn that he is also priest from the witness of the Father: 'You are a priest forever after the order of Melchizedek'. Aaron was made the first priest of the law by being anointed with chrism, but the Father did not say, 'after the order of Aaron', in case it might be thought that our Saviour's priesthood also was derived. The priesthood which Aaron possessed was hereditary; but our Saviour's priesthood is not passed on to anyone else because he will continue forever as priest, as Scripture says: 'You are a priest forever after the order of Melchizedek'.

He is therefore our Saviour according to the flesh, and both king and priest, but his anointing is spiritual and not bodily. The kings and priests of the Jews were given their position by bodily anointing with oil. One man was not both: each was either king or priest. To Christ alone belong perfection and fullness in all things, for he came to fulfil the law also.

Although they could not as individuals be both at the same time, they were called 'Messiahs' or 'anointed ones' because they had received bodily anointing as kings or priests. Our Saviour on the other hand, who is truly

Christ, the Anointed One, was anointed by the Holy Spirit, that he might fulfil what was written of him: 'Therefore God, your God, has anointed you with the oil of gladness above your fellows'. That he was anointed more than those who share the same name 'Messiah' lies in the fact that he was anointed with the oil of gladness, which properly means the Holy Spirit.

We learn that this is the case from our Saviour himself. When he took and opened the book of Isaiah, and read: 'The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he has anointed me', he said that the prophecy was fulfilled then in the presence of his hearers. Peter too, the chief of the apostles, taught that the chrism which shows our Saviour to be the Anointed One is the Holy Spirit himself, which is also the power of God, when in the Acts of the Apostles he spoke to the most faithful and merciful man, the centurion. Among other things, he said: 'Beginning from Galilee after the baptism which John preached, Jesus of Nazareth, whom God anointed with the Holy Spirit and with power, went about doing great and wonderful things, and healing all who were oppressed by the devil'.

You notice that Peter said Jesus was anointed according to the flesh with the Holy Spirit and with power. And so this same Jesus truly became Christ, the Anointed One, according to the flesh, being made by the anointing of the Holy Spirit both king and priest forever.

Responsorial. *cfr. Heb. 5: 5-6*

R: Contemplate the glory of the Lord: he entered into the world to save the nations. * He is the king of justice: his kingdom will have no end.

V: Jesus has entered as a precursor for us, having become high priest forever of the order of Melchizedek.

R: He is the king of justice: his kingdom will have no end.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Is. 59: 1 – 14*

Penitence and salvation.

A reading from the prophet Isaiah.

Behold, the LORD's hand is not shortened, that it cannot save, or his ear dull, that it cannot hear; but your iniquities have made a separation between you and your God, and your sins have hid his face from you so that he does not hear.

For your hands are defiled with blood and your fingers with iniquity; your lips have spoken lies, your tongue mutters wickedness. No one enters suit justly, no one goes to law honestly; they rely on empty pleas, they speak lies, they conceive mischief and bring forth iniquity. They hatch adders' eggs, they weave the spider's web; he who eats their eggs dies, and from one which is crushed a viper is hatched. Their webs will not serve as clothing; men will not cover themselves with what they make. Their works are works of iniquity, and deeds of violence are in their hands.

Their feet run to evil, and they make haste to shed innocent blood; their thoughts are thoughts of iniquity, desolation and destruction are in their highways. The way of peace they know not, and there is no justice in their paths; they have made their roads crooked, no one who goes in them knows peace. Therefore justice is far from us, and righteousness does not overtake us; we look for light, and behold, darkness, and for brightness, but we walk in gloom.

We grope for the wall like the blind, we grope like those who have no eyes; we stumble at noon as in the twilight, among those in full vigour we are like dead men.

We all growl like bears, we moan and moan like doves; we look for justice, but there is none; for salvation, but it is far from us. For our transgressions are multiplied before you, and our sins testify against us; for our transgressions are with us, and we know our iniquities: transgressing, and denying the LORD, and turning away from following our God, speaking oppression and revolt, conceiving and uttering from the heart lying words. Justice is turned back, and righteousness stands afar off; for truth has fallen in the public squares, and uprightness cannot enter.

Responsorial. *Is. 59: 12; 1 Jn. 1: 8*

R: Our crimes are many in front of you, our sins witness against us. * Our sins are in front of us and we know our iniquity.

V: If we say that we are without sin, we deceive ourselves and the truth is not in us.

R: Our sins are in front of us and we know our iniquity.

Second Reading. *Patericon 196*

Convert and return to the Lord.

A reading from the “Sentences of the fathers” of John Mosco”, monk.

Convert and return in the fear of your God: fast, pray, cry, invoke with constancy. Give me the occasion to praise you and to make your good works rise up to God, the sweet perfume of your fast, of your almsgiving, of your prayer, of your charity towards the poor, so that my face may rejoice with my brothers the angels and the Holy Spirit may descend on you: and immediately you will be numbered with the just and the good, who hear the invitation to enter into the joy on the day of judgement.

Return, my soul, to the Lord with penance so that he can draw you near to him, for he is good. What is penance? To abandon sin and its desires, to leave the old works, and to accept a rule of life with frequent fasts, assiduous orations, dedications that are not lazy, with tears day and night. Search for the love of the poor, because for God it is better than a sacrifice offered to him; cast away the laxity from your body and give satisfaction instead to the soul; purify your stains in order to know the sweetness of the Lord, and his light will descend on you and you will be free from the temptations of the enemy; because the Lord has promised to welcome those who appeal to him, giving them his mercy. Pay attention: abandon the worldly gatherings, eating and drinking too much, in order not to lose that which the Lord has promised to the good and to the just. And thus, O soul, your dwelling will now be constructed with your good works, and your lamp will shine in the heavens with the oil of your mercy. Believe the word pronounced by our Lord in the holy gospel: “I am meek and humble and my burden is light. Come to me, all of you who are burdened and oppressed, and I will restore you” (Mt. 11: 29, 30, 28).

Poor soul, many are your sins, but his mercy is greater than the sins of the whole universe. Draw near to his forgiveness and to his mercy, and he will make his Spirit shine over you. Wash your sins with tears, and the good will descend in you.

Behold I have explained everything to you and I have shown you the way of life, which is penance. It will draw you near to the Lord and it will make you taste the heavenly food. Clothe the poor with your clothes and protect them from the cold of winter, feed them abundantly multiplying your fast. Convert and return to the Lord, draw near to his infinite mercy, promised to those who invoke him.

O soul, our Lord has said: "As to that day and to that hour, no one knows it" (Mt. 24: 36). Run fast therefore in order to reach salvation, make your offering, and acquire patience in acting, humility, silence, purity, love of the poor, and accumulate works of justice. If you do this, every good will come on you. And to our Lord Jesus Christ Son of God, be glory and honour forever and ever. Amen.

Responsorial. *Act. 17: 31; 14: 16*

R: God after having passed over the times of ignorance * now orders all men of all places to repent, because he has established a day in which he will judge the earth with justice.

V: He in past generations, has let all nations go their own way.

R: Now he orders all men of all places to repent, because he has established a day in which he will judge the earth with justice.

Gospel. *Mt. 9: 14 – 17*

Can the friends be in mourning when the groom is in their midst?

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

Then the disciples of John came to him, saying, "Why do we and the Pharisees fast, but your disciples do not fast?" And Jesus said to them, "Can the wedding guests mourn as long as the bridegroom is with them? The days will come, when the bridegroom is taken away from them, and then they will fast. And no one puts a piece of unshrunk cloth on an old garment, for the patch tears away from the garment, and a worse tear is made. Neither is new wine put into old wineskins; if it is, the skins burst, and the wine is spilled, and the skins are destroyed; but new wine is put into fresh wineskins, and so both are preserved."